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Introduction

Improving my sleep schedule and sleeping early was more than just a behavior change, it turned into an opportunity for me to understand myself and the factors being healthy play in our daily Lifes. This behavioral change experience taught me how much very little changes can change not just my energy but my mood, daily productivity, and my view on life. By reflecting on what I learned in this course and my experience,

Understanding Health and Behavior

Before taking this course, I did not think much about the link between health and behavior. Sleep, for example, was something I just did because I had to, not something I could manage or improve. Through the lectures and readings with my reflections, I started seeing how habits shape our daily lives. One idea that stood out was self-efficacy, which is the belief that you can achieve anything. This concept helped me to stay consistent with my new sleep routine because I started believing I could actually change my behavior.

In the book Atomic Habits, James Clear explained that our behaviors often fail because we try to change them all at once instead of taking it step by step and not connecting them to our personal values. This was very interesting to me. I realized that my goal was not just to feel less tired. I wanted better sleep so I could focus on my bigger goals, like getting to school early and studying before class and also growing my YouTube channel. It showed me that small actions, like sticking to a bedtime routine, could lead to bigger, long-term benefits. (Clear, J. (2018)) Learning how my environment affected my behavior. For example, scrolling on my phone in bed kept me awake for hours. Changing small things, like putting my phone away before brushing my teeth, made it easier for me to fall asleep. It showed me that small actions, like sticking to a bedtime routine, could lead to bigger, long-term benefits.

Personal Connection

At first, trying to sleep early felt weird. It was like I was forcing myself to miss out on things. I had to leave the comfort of my old routine, even if it wasn't good for me. But over time, I noticed small wins that made it easier to keep up with the change. For example, I woke up one morning feeling rested enough to finish an assignment before breakfast which is something I had never done before. It proved that better sleep was not just about rest, but it was making me more productive and less stressed.

This course also made me reflect on why I stayed up late in the first place. It wasn't just about watching Netflix or doomscrolling on TikTok. it was a way to avoid the stress of unfinished work. I learned that these are habits we develop to deal with stress but end up making things worse. Identifying this helped me replace those behaviors with healthier ones, like journaling about my day and what i want to achieve the next day or listening to music before bed.

Implications for My Life

This behavior change has inspired me to be more mindful about all my habits, not just sleep. For example, I started habit stacking which is a special form of implementing our intention. Rather than pairing the new habit with a particular time and location, you pair it with a current habit. I pair brushing my teeth while turning off my phone as a signal to get ready for bed (Clear, 2014). These small changes have made it easier to stick to my routine. Beyond my personal habits, I also started sharing what I have learned with others. Some friends have told me they want to improve their sleep too, and it feels good to share what's worked for me. On a broader level, I now understand how small health behaviors connect to bigger goals. This process taught me that improving one area of your life can have a great impact, improving your focus, relationships, and overall well-being.

Conclusion

Changing my sleep schedule taught me more than I expected. I learned that small and intentional changes can lead to big improvements over time. Understanding the reasons behind my habits, like how my environment and coping mechanisms influenced me, was key to making a perfect change. This course helped me see that healthy behaviors are more than just physical well-being, but they are the foundation for achieving your goals and becoming the best version of yourself. Sleep isn't just about rest anymore; it's a way to build the life I want.

REFKLECTIONS

Clear, J. (2014, August). How to Build New Habits by Taking Advantage of Old Ones. James Clear. https://jamesclear.com/habit-stacking

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